

Secure Coding: JavaScript Hijacking

Secure Coding: JavaScript Hijacking - Brian Chess, seclists.org.

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Content

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[[image: securecoding logo]](<https://seclists.org/securecoding/>)

Secure Coding mailing list archives

JavaScript Hijacking

From: brian at fortifysoftware.com (Brian Chess) *Date:* Sun, 01 Apr 2007 21:03:05 -0700

I've been getting questions about Ajax/Web 2.0 **for** a few years now. Most of the time the first question is along these lines: "Does Ajax cause any **new** security problems?" Until recently, my answer has been right in line with the answers I've heard **from** other corners of the world: "**No.**"

Then I've gone on to explain that Ajax doesn't change the rules of the game, but it does tilt the playing field. **For** example:

- By splitting your code between a client and a server, you increase your opportunity **for** misplacing input validation logic and access control checks.
- Dynamic testing tools tend to have a harder time with Ajax apps.

Now my story has changed. We've found a **new** type of vulnerability that only affects Ajax-style apps. We call the attack "**JavaScript Hijacking**". It enables an attacker to read confidential information **from** vulnerable sites. The attack works because many Ajax apps have given up on the "**x**" in Ajax. Instead of XML, they're **using** JavaScript as a data transport format.

The problem is that web browsers don't protect JavaScript the same way they protect HTML, so a malicious web site can peek into some of the JavaScript returned **from** a vulnerable Ajax app. We've looked at a lot of Ajax frameworks over the past few weeks, including Google's GWT, Microsoft Atlas, and half a dozen open source frameworks. Almost all of them make it easy **for** developers to write vulnerable code. Some of them **require** developers to write vulnerable code.

Our write-up on the problem, along with our proposed solution, is here:

[http://www.fortify.com/servlet/downloads/public/JavaScript_Hijacking.pdf](http://www.fortify.com/servlet/downloads/public/JavaScript_Hijacking.pdf)

Enjoy,
Brian

Current thread:

- **JavaScript Hijacking** *Brian Chess (Apr 01)*
- <Possible follow-ups>
- **JavaScript Hijacking** *Stefano Di Paola (Apr 02)*
- **JavaScript Hijacking** *Brian Chess (Apr 02)*
- **JavaScript Hijacking** *Stefano Di Paola (Apr 03)*
- **JavaScript Hijacking** *Frederik De Keukelaere (Apr 05)*

- [Foundations of Security: What Every Programmer Needs to Know](#) *McGovern, James F (HTSC, IT)* (Apr 04)
- [JavaScript Hijacking](#) *Brian Chess (Apr 19)*

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